

The queen-tempo budget



SC-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The early queen recapture costs time when White develops with an attack. Black accepts that cost for a clear central structure, but cannot afford unrelated queen excursions.

HOW TO DECIDE

Before every queen move, list White's next attacks from pawns, knights and bishops. Choose a square with a safe follow-up route and spend subsequent moves developing.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Nc3, Bd2, c4, Nb5 and discovered attacks can combine. A queen that has a legal square now may have no comfortable square one move later.

BOARD DRILL

At each main-line diagram, name two potential queen attacks and a legal escape route.

Why ...c6 and ...e6 are useful



The discovered attack behind Nc3



SC-09 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

With Bd2 and Qa5, the c3 knight can move away and uncover a bishop attack along d2-c3-b4-a5. A knight move may therefore have two separate threats.

HOW TO DECIDE

When Nc3 moves, trace the diagonal immediately. Check whether ...c6 gives a safe queen retreat and whether the knight's new square attacks another piece.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Nd5, Ne4 or Nb5 may gain a decisive tempo. Focusing only on the knight's destination misses the bishop behind it.

BOARD DRILL

Set up the Bd2 branch and name all legal c3-knight moves that reveal the bishop line.

The light-squared bishop decision



SC-04 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

Developing the c8 bishop actively is one of Black's main resources. Exchanging it for Nf3 can reduce e5 pressure but gives White the bishop pair.

HOW TO DECIDE

Compare the recapture and resulting pawn structure before ...Bxf3. If preserving the bishop, identify a safe retreat after h3, g4 or Nh4.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can chase the bishop while gaining space. A bishop on g6 may face h4-h5; a bishop on h5 can be restricted by g4.

BOARD DRILL

Play one endpoint with ...Bxf3 and another preserving the bishop. Compare e5 control and king safety.

Central breaks release the position



SC-05 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

Black often has less space, so a well-timed ...c5 or ...e5 is the route to activity. The break must be supported by development and king safety.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension. Identify the file that opens and which rook reaches it first. If an isolated pawn results, assess its activity and weakness.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can open the center before Black castles. A thematic break can be a tactical mistake when the queen or king is exposed.

BOARD DRILL

In a main-line endpoint, prepare one break with a useful piece move and state the best white response.

Opposite-side castling



SC-02 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

If White castles long and Black short, both players may attack with pawns. The winner is often decided by concrete tempi and central counterplay, not by who pushes more pawns.

HOW TO DECIDE

Count how many moves each side needs to open a file near the opposing king. Check whether a central exchange gains a tempo or exposes your own king first.

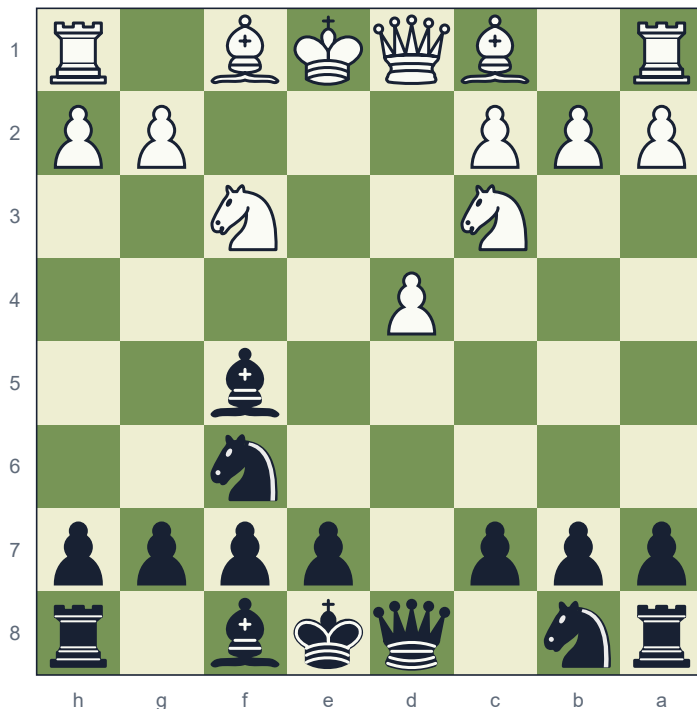
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White's g4-h4 advances can hit Bf5 while preparing an attack. Black's queen must avoid becoming a tactical target in the race.

BOARD DRILL

At a long-castling branch endpoint, write a three-move attacking plan for each side and test the first move for checks and captures.

Defending the Blackmar-Diemer initiative



SC-15 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

An extra pawn can be useful if Black develops and keeps the king safe. Trying to preserve every pawn while White brings all pieces into the attack is a common practical failure.

HOW TO DECIDE

Develop with defense when possible, count pressure on f7 and compare returning material to exchange an attacker. A queen trade can be valuable if it removes the initiative.

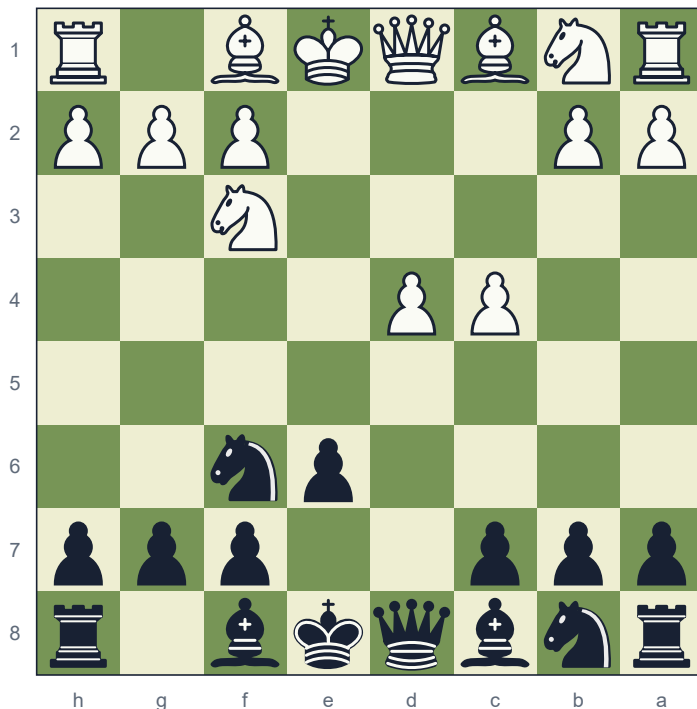
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may use Ne5, Bc4 and Qe2. The strongest threat may be a developing move rather than an immediate capture.

BOARD DRILL

Play the gambit endpoint with the goal of completing development. Do not make a second pawn capture unless you can justify its time cost.

Scandinavian endgame targets



SC-19 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The opening can lead to a white isolated d-pawn, a black e6-c6 structure or doubled black f-pawns in sidelines. Each structure calls for different exchanges.

HOW TO DECIDE

Against an isolated pawn, blockade and trade active attacking pieces when appropriate. With doubled f-pawns, retain activity and avoid a passive pawn-only ending without checking it.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White's space and bishop pair can outweigh a nominal pawn weakness. A blockade square must be secure and useful.

BOARD DRILL

Identify the actual pawn weakness at an endpoint, then name a piece trade that would help and one that would hurt.

Loose pieces and forks



SC-03 audit position - White to move

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

Pins and discovered attacks



SC-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

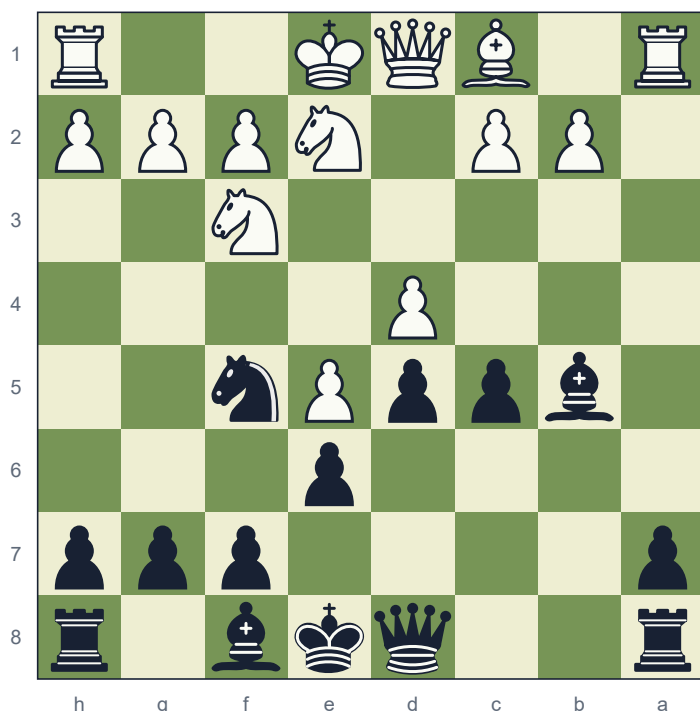
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



SC-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



SC-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

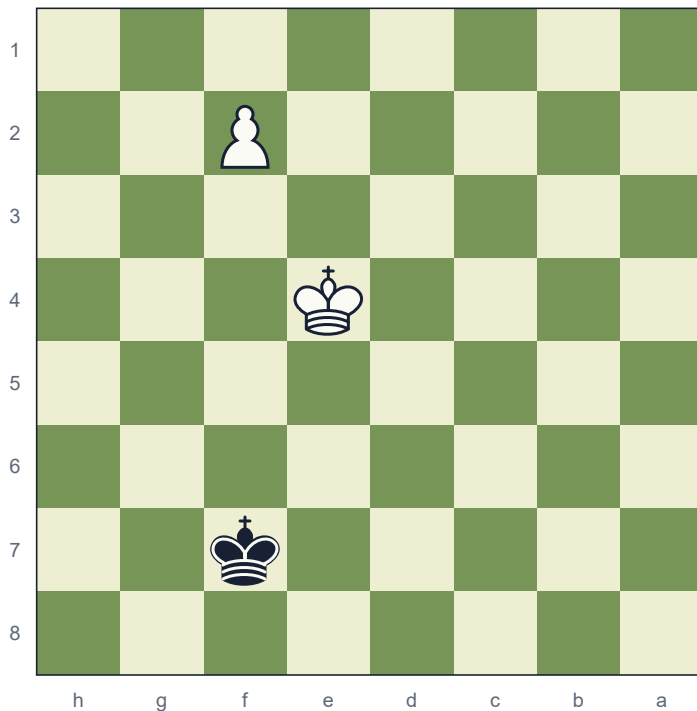
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

A central queen can be hit by several different pieces. Do not spend the next move on an unrelated wing pawn.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

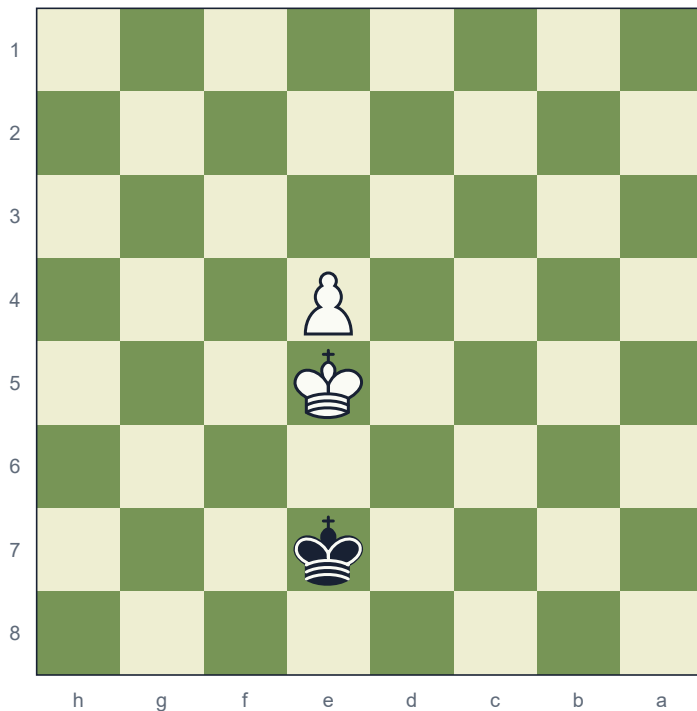
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

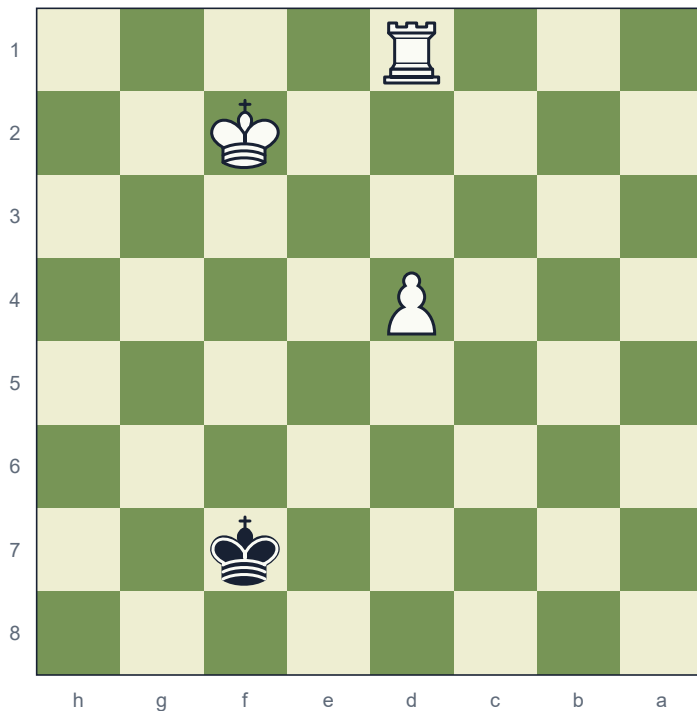
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

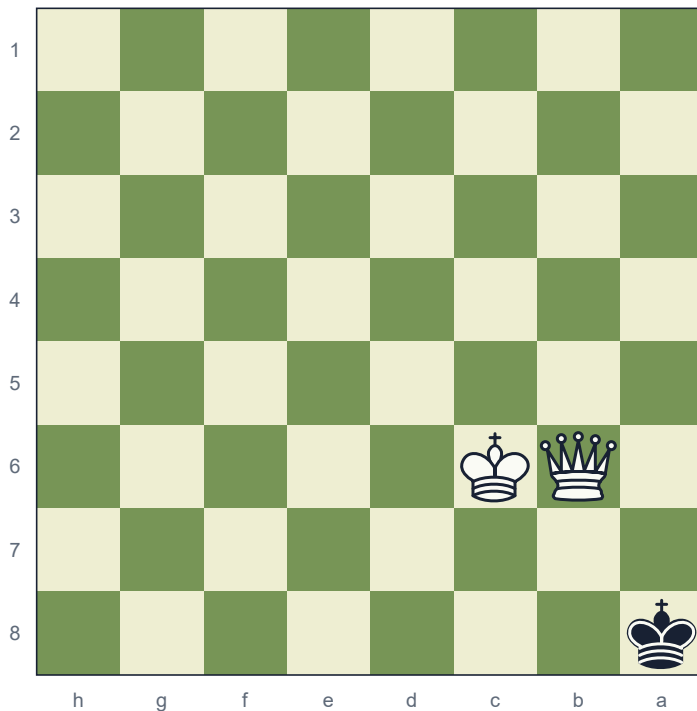
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

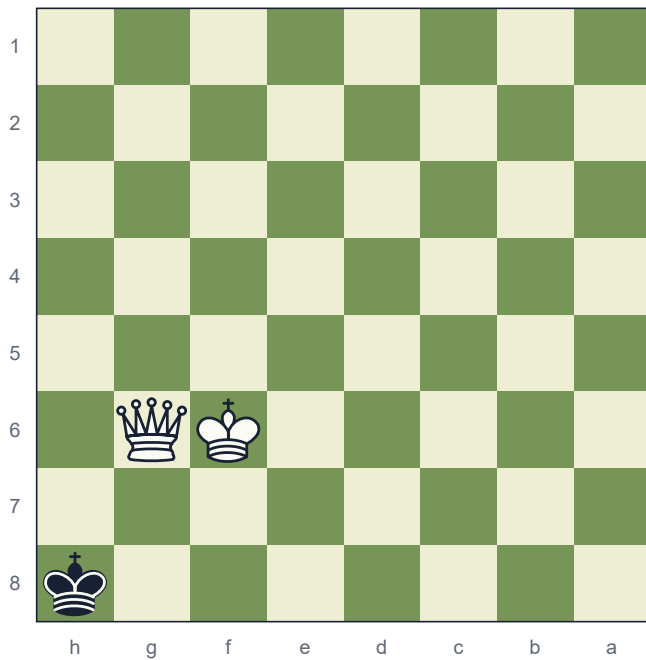
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

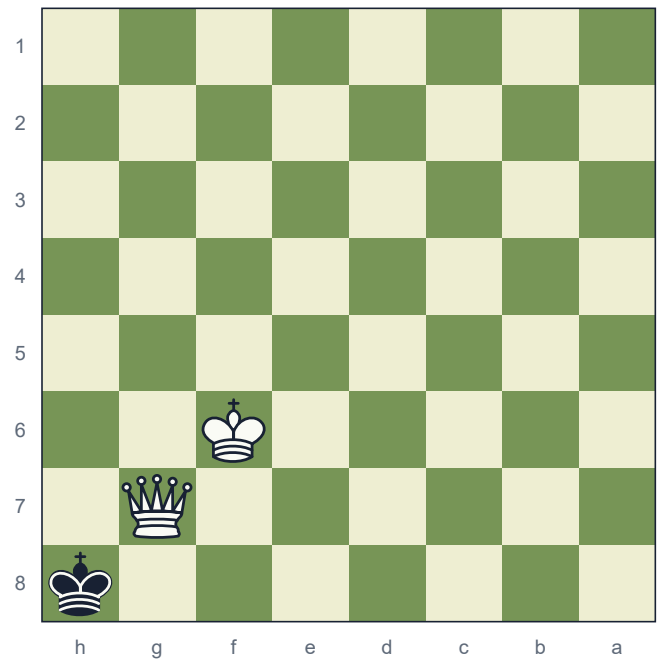
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

The opening can lead to a white isolated d-pawn, a black e6-c6 structure or doubled black f-pawns in sidelines. Each structure calls for different exchanges.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.